support and both Fadallah and the outfit's leader Hussain Musavi were deeply entrenched in Khomeini's inner circle.

Hayyan sent a message through one of his contacts in Beirut to arrange Vipul's meeting with Fadlallah. They waited for almost two months for a response from the cleric when a newspaper report on 8 March 1985 triggered a shock. A car bomb had exploded in Bir el-Abed in south Beirut and initial reports suggested that Fadlallah was the target of the strike that had killed around eighty people. However, the preacher had narrowly escaped the attack.

In his first sermon after the attack, Fadallah blamed American intelligence for the bombing. Hayyan was later informed by a Hezbollah contact working as a sleeper cell in Syrian-controlled Bekaa Valley that the time was not ripe for a meeting with Fadallah. However, the contact added that Vipul and Hayyan should move to Kuwait and wait for a signal. The sleeper cell also warned Hayyan and Vipul that the Israeli intelligence agency Mossad and the CIA were keeping a close watch on Hezbollah contacts and a thoughtless move could spoil the espionage operation. The CIA believed that the Hezbollah posed a serious threat to American interests both as an aggressive terrorist network and as a rising fundamentalist political movement in Lebanon and its growing ability to strike the US personnel and installations would hamper the conduct of regular US diplomatic, military and commercial business in the Middle East and Western Europe.

In June 1985, Vipul and Hayyan, with the help of Fadallah, met Abdullah Shirazi in Kuwait. Shirazi headed a small Shia group known as the Jund al-Imam, but had a larger influence over Shia leaders in Iran. He promised to arrange a meeting with